What Siblings Do

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/78748071.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Rape/Non-Con

Category:
Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Characters:
Castaspella (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Wing and Claw Apocrypha, Date Rape Drug/Roofies, Date Rape, Darkfluff, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Of Wing and Claw side stories

Collections:
Of Wing & Claw - Apocrypha

Stats:
Published: 2026-02-02 Words: 7,329 Chapters: 1/1

What Siblings Do

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/78748071.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Rape/Non-Con

Category:
Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Characters:
Castaspella (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Wing and Claw Apocrypha, Date Rape Drug/Roofies, Date Rape, Darkfluff, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Of Wing and Claw side stories

Collections:
Of Wing & Claw - Apocrypha

Stats:
Published: 2026-02-02 Words: 7,329 Chapters: 1/1

What Siblings Do

by Paganaidd

Summary

Tonight was the first eclipse of spring, a night of celebration in Mystacor. One of the few truly dark nights of the year. The Ritual of Mirrors renewed the wards.

After the ceremony, the city was filled with dancing and laughter. Music spilled from open balconies. People feasted and exchanged gifts under lanterns that shimmered like constellations.

Akrash had lost track of Ariel early on. Last he saw her, she was with Khedir.

It was very late. Third watch of the night. Uncertain footsteps zig-zagged down the hall, thumping into the wall. Was she drunk?

She didn’t usually drink.

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Mystacor
Spring Equinox

Three years (or thereabouts) after Princess C'yara's abduction

Akrash stared at the white-furred, blue-eyed stranger in the mirror. No one from his old life would ever recognize him. Even after months of getting used to the changes, he still caught himself staring.

He had started experimenting with colors. White went with everything, right? And discovered he loved pastels. Another quiet rebellion. Another way to distance himself from *them*. The ones who always insisted he dress with "due respect for the dignity of his house."

His mom (*he loved that Casta let him call her that*) only smiled at whatever he wore. Some days, he put colors together *just* to imagine Kellam and Varlainn losing their minds over him in turquoise and purple shimmersilk.

This robe, a deep blue and silver, had gone over particularly well this evening with a young woman who had been making eyes at him in class.

Tonight was the first eclipse of spring, a night of celebration in Mystacor. One of the few truly dark nights of the year. Castaspella, as head sorceress, had performed the Ritual of Mirrors that renewed the wards protecting the realm until the moonlight returned.

After the ceremony, the city was filled with dancing and laughter. Music spilled from open balconies. People feasted and exchanged

gifts under lanterns that shimmered like constellations.

Ariel and Akrash had walked their mother to bed after the ritual. The yearly reset always left her exhausted.

It was one of the reasons the next three days were holidays—none of the council sorcerers would be working.

Akrash had lost track of Ariel early on. Last he saw her, she was with a young man from one of his classes. Not someone he was friendly with. The younger son of one of the kings of a neighboring principality, Khedir was both handsome and charming.

Something about him set Akrash's teeth on edge

It was very late. Third watch of the night. Most of the revellers were on their way home now. If Ariel didn't show up soon he would go looking for her.

As though he had summoned her, the front door opened and shut. Uncertain footsteps zig-zagged down the hall, thumping into the wall. Was she drunk? She didn't usually drink.

A noise like a tiny sob and another thump against the wall.

"Are you okay?" Akrash opened his door.

Ariel jumped, green eyes wide and blood shot. Her hair was a mess, looking as though she had been taking it in her two hands and pulling it. Her shoes and a bundle of cloth were in her hand. If she'd had a tail, it would have been puffed out and his own hackles rose in response.

"M'okay," she slurred. "J'st need to get to bed." Turning away, she staggered into the wall and bounced off of it, every step a struggle to stay upright.

The odor of blood, sex, and distress pervaded her scent, when she staggered into him.

“Ariel?”

She stared up at him. “Wha?”

“How much did you drink?” It couldn’t be alcohol, though. If she got drunk enough to be this sloppy, she would reek of it.

“I dunno. Maybe one?”

“I can smell blood on you, Did you… trip or something?”

Almost comically, she looked at her hands and then she bent to look at her knees. He noticed that her tights were gone.

When she straightened she looked confused. A terrible suspicion began to form.

“Ariel, look at me.” He gently took her face in his hands, tilting it towards the light. Her pupils were blown, even though the hallway light was on, swallowing the green of her irises. He focused and summoned a mage light, narrowing it down. “I’m going to shine a light in your eyes, Okay?”

Her pupils were equal, but reacted only sluggishly.

“Ow!” she protested, shoving his shoulder. “Quit. That hurts.”

Drugged.

The word was a cold stone in his stomach.

“Akrash?” She blinked as though she was surprised he was there. “C’n you get me home? I-I’m scared.

The admission of weakness made Akrash’s stomach turn over. Something was *very* wrong here.

“Okay, I’ll take you home.” He didn’t bother to tell her they were already home, instead he tightened his hold on her waist and half dragged her to her room.

“Did something happen?” It really wasn’t any of his business who she slept with, but smelling of blood and distress was never good.

“Happen?” Her eyes wandered vaguely around the room before sharpening and returning to his face. “No! No. It’s fine. I’m just a little tired.”

“You are not fine.” Akrash had never seen Ariel *less f*ine.

“I am!” A high pitched little cry. “Just leave me alone!” Tears trickled down her cheeks.

“That’s not happening.” There was no way he was leaving her alone now. Discreetly, he invoked a diagnostic spell that looked for common intoxicants.

Waking up Castaspella was out of the question, she would be unrousable for the next few hours. And nonfunctional for at least twenty-four hours after that.

“Ariel? Do you know if someone could have slipped you anything?” Akrash asked gently. The runes of the diagnostic spell told him it wasn’t moonflower, or alcohol, or anything else he was familiar with.

Peering at him with eyes half-focused she said, “I heard some folks were doing Glitter.”

Glitter. He’d heard of it.

“Do you want me to find a healer?” Akrash asked, pushing the hair out of her face as he looked more closely.

There. A glaze of shining particles on her cheeks.

“No. I need a shower.” Ariel muttered, sounding petulant. “I'm disgusting.”

“How about I run you a bath?” Washing it off of her skin would be a good first step, but he doubted her ability to stand. “You’re kind of unsteady right now.”

“Yeah. Okay.” Her eyes filled with tears. “I just keep smelling him on me. I can’t stand it.”

That was really not good.

“Stay here.”

She nodded miserably.

He turned on the tub water, hurrying back into her bedroom. “Ariel?”

While he was in the bathroom, she had pulled her dress off, standing only in her bra. Growing up in the Horde meant she didn’t have a whole lot of body modesty, so it was not her undressing that made Akrash freeze up in the doorway.

Dark red and purple blotches marred the freckled skin of her upper arms, her neck, stark against her pale skin. Above her bra were strange half crescent marks. Almost against his will, his eyes dropped to her lower body.

More of those marks. Suspiciously regular.

Fingerprints on her thighs and round bruises on her stomach. A dried trickle of blood on the inside of her leg halfway to her knee.

The meaning of those crescents came to him. They were the blunt teethmarks of an Etherian.

“I turned the water on." He kept his voice calm; fortunately he was an excellent liar.

“Thanks. I was gonna do that.” The makeup around her eyes was smudged and it gave her an owlish look as she blinked her confusion.

He cleared his throat and he asked calmly, “Ariel? Where are those bruises from?”

Eyebrows furrowed as she seemed to need to think through her answer. “We… Khedir… we went back to his room.”

“Khedir?” Akrash felt his ears pin back. “Did he hurt you?”

She shook her head, but then she nodded.

“I never told him no.” She looked down at herself again. “He just… got a little rough.” She wiped tears on her shoulder. “I should have said… something.”

“Stay here for a minute. I need my tablet, okay?” He also needed to get something on that bitemark. The skin wasn’t broken, but he did not want to take chances.

Hesitantly she nodded.

He raced to his room and grabbed his tablet and his first aid kit. That had everything she would need to get her through the night (he hoped). He took out a piece of gauze from his kit.

When he came back, she was sitting on her bed twisting her hands together in her lap, examining the bruising on her chest.

“Ariel? The tub’s full. Do you need help?”

“No.” Her fingers traced the bite mark on her breast. “Did that… It did, didn’t it?”

“Ariel…?”

Burying both hands in her hair she pulled on it. “He-he said....” She sucked in a loud breath. “That’s all I was good for. He said that I was a good slave. I was good at doing what I was told.”

Involuntarily, Akrash’s ears pinned back. He did not want to hear this. But for her, he would listen, if that’s what she needed.

For days after the spellworking that had changed his body, he had been too weak to leave bed. Ariel had set up camp in his room while he recovered, volunteering to stay with him so Casta could go to work. She'd helped him tip broth into his mouth when his hands shook too badly. Helped him totter back and forth to the bathroom.

And she'd never asked a single question, never criticized. She even curbed her snark. The only comment she'd made was, "I didn't know that magicats had a larval phase." At his look of confusion, she grinned even more. "You know, like a butterfly."

Halfmoon didn't have butterflies, only the moonwhite moths that spun cocoons that became shimmersilk strands among the luaha trees. When he told her this, she'd brought him books about Etherian butterflies to divert him during his convalescence.

She'd bought him his first set of pastel robes, the same blue and purple as the butterflies that lived in the gardens.

Later, when he felt better and he tried to thank her, she'd waved it off. "It's what sisters do, right?"

"M' gonna be sick." The plaintive moan was the only warning he had. Fortunately, the trashcan was right there. She dropped to her knees and he pulled her hair out of her face, muttering a stream of soothing nonsense.

When she finally stopped, she sat back wiping her mouth. "Thanks," she muttered.

"Don't worry about it. It's what brothers do, right?" He smiled at her and pushed her hair back from her damp forehead. He took gauze from the first aid kit and wiped both of her cheeks, collecting some of the residue on her face.

"I'm cold." She dripped with sweat.

"Come on." He helped her to her feet and walked with her to the

bathroom. “I’ll be out here if you need anything. Do you want me to bring you something to change into?”

“Yeah… “ She sounded vague and confused again.

“Don’t worry about it, I’ll find something.”

Akrash grabbed a shirt and robe Ariel often wore in the evenings. He hoped it was something she found comforting. As he reached around the door to put the bundle on the counter, he peeked into the bathroom, mostly to make sure her head was still above water.

She had her forehead on her knees and her shoulders shook. Quietly Akrash drew back; Ariel’s sobs were silent. “Show no weakness” was the first and last law of the Horde.

He settled down with his back against the wall to read about Glitter, where he could hear her move and check when she was silent for too long.

Half a page had him apoplectic with rage.

The effects were listed clinically.

- *Dissociation*
- Suggestibility
- Short term memory impairment
- Sedation
- Disinhibition
- Loss of muscle control

The legitimate uses were mostly in children; for them it had an excellent safety margin. It could be ingested by breathing or swallowing.

In patients with high magical aptitude, dosage becomes critical. Effects include: inability to summon magic, profound muscle weakness, severely impaired judgment, and in rare cases, respiratory depression.

Note: This drug should NEVER be used on sorcerers without careful dosing and medical supervision.

Whoever had done this had rendered her unable to fight back, unable to think clearly, unable to even speak.

Had made her *helpless*.

The way his parents had made him helpless. The way the binding spells had trapped his words in his throat.

He understood exactly what had been stolen from her and began to plan.

"Akrash?" The uncertainty in her voice tore his heart; she seemed like a ghost inhabiting her own skin. Like she was puppeting her body instead of inhabiting it.

She stood in the doorway, wrapped up in the robe, looking somehow smaller than she normally did. Akrash stood, putting his fury away in the face of her raw pain and shock.

"I'm here." He'd have to stay with her tonight and watch her. "Come on. You should go to bed."

"I hurt all over."

Akrash's claws sank into his palms as he thought back to the bruises he'd seen. They weren't defensive. They had been

inflicted just to cause pain. “Do you want something for it?”

She looked at him with narrowed eyes, and his heart seized at the flicker of distrust. Then she nodded.

“Are you sure you don’t want me to find a healer?” he asked her, sitting back down on her bed.

Half-closed eyes rolled open. “No healer.”

“Okay. I brought you some stuff for that bite. And some mild pain killers that won’t interact with the Glitter.”

“Glitter?” She shook her head. “I don’t fuck with that stuff.”

“I know. Someone slipped you some.”

“Is that why I feel like this?”

He nodded. Another reason to stay with her tonight.

She pulled the collar of her shirt aside so Akrash could put some ointment on the bite. When his hand touched her skin, she jumped back with a cry.

He pulled back too, alarmed when her scent spiked with pure terror, and her face went so pale she was nearly green.

“It’s okay! It’s just me. You’re safe.” Akrash held his hands up so she could see them.

“Akrash? What?” She sounded both more alert and more afraid, more aware that she was not thinking right. “What’s happening?”

According to the entry on Glitter, this was normal. It made it no less upsetting. It was as if he were witnessing the onset of her shock and horror every few minutes and nothing he had done (or could do) would provide comfort for more than a minute or two.

It was going to be a long night.

Moving slowly, he sat on the edge of the bed. “You got dosed with Glitter.” It hurt as much to say it the third time as the first.

“I… did, didn’t I?” She pushed her hair back over her shoulder. “I sort of remember?”

Maybe that meant it was wearing off.

“Can you tell me what you remember?”

“Why?”

The question was so unexpected Akrash could not think of an answer.

“I just want to forget it.” Tears started down her cheeks again.

“But you…”

He wasn’t sure what to say. Didn’t she want to report it?

“Ariel. He hurt you.”

“No. Leave it. It’s not your problem.” Her teeth clenched and she screwed her eyes shut. “I knew what I was doing. I was a fool, but I knew.”

“Ariel?” he took her hands in his. “It is my problem. You’re my sister.”

“You’re my sister.” He put his hand on her cheek, searched her eyes. “You can tell me as much or as little as you want.”

Ariel stared back. The words felt important, but she couldn't pull a reply together. She focused. Why she was here, what had happened?

The last few hours flashed by in a series of jumbled scenes.

Khedir had only started at Mystacor last year, so Ariel didn't know him well, but he was charming. She'd run into him at one of the student parties. He'd stopped to chat and had been quite sweet.

And then, things became… odd. Her memory jumped and she remembered walking with Khedir down a long hallway to his rooms.

Someone asked if she was okay,

"No," she muttered. "This isn't right." She couldn't tell if she said it out loud or not.

Khedir had waved them off.

They were in his room together. It seemed to make sense, although a voice in the back of Ariel's head seemed to be screaming a warning the rest of her didn't hear.

Then she was lying on her back and she was pushing at his shoulder. She tried to summon her magic. She couldn't get her mouth to work. She tried to hit him, but her body would not obey her.

"You're very good at this."

What did he mean by that?

"Doing what you're told. You should have stayed a slave.That's the only thing you're really good at, isn't it?"

And then it *hurt*. A bright red flash of agony, like the force of him splitting her in two.

"Oh, don't cry. It's not like it matters, you're hardly a virgin."

His weight on top of her, her hands held to her sides. The crook of his shoulder near her face. She opened her mouth and sank her teeth into the flesh there, biting down like she had once bitten leather while they straightened her broken arm. A way to redirect the pain that tore through her.

Blood filled her mouth.

"*Ah! You bitch!"* A hand went around her throat. She had to let go.

Pain on her breast this time.

A slap on her cheek. That helped, somehow. It brought her back from the dizzy fog.

He got off of her. Left the room. Her clothes? On the floor by the bed. She pulled her dress over her head, grabbed her shoes and underwear, escaping before he came back.

Staggering, confused, she made it to a crowded place. She thought she heard him call for her. Then he was beside her. Trying to walk her back to his room. Telling people she just had too much.

She still couldn't explain what happened, and he sounded so sincere.

Then a semi-familiar voice said, "Miss Ariel does seem to have had too much. I'll walk her home."

The woman took her arm, even as Khedir tried to explain that Ariel would be better off with him. "No, Her Grace sent me to look for her," the woman told him.

Did she? How was Casta awake?

They walked slowly back to Casta's apartment. Ariel still had her shoes, leggings and underwear in a bundle in her hands.

"Are you all right?" The woman asked.

"I don't know." At least if Ariel was home, she'd be safe.

"I can get you a healer, if you need one," the woman whispered.

"No! No healers," she squeaked, practically falling in through the door and slamming it shut to stand confused in the foyer because for a moment she did not recognize where she was.

And then Akrash found her.

The memory released her and she was back in her room, Akrash's hands warm around hers, his blue eyes full of quiet fury that wasn't directed at her.

Her *brother* found her.

"You only need to give me a name," he said softly. "And I'll take care of him." There was no mistaking Akrash's intent.

"No. I told you, leave it. It was… it was just a bad date." She couldn't let him get in trouble.

"Ariel." Akrash squeezed her hands. "What can I do to help?"

"I don't know!" The words came out as a wail and Ariel immediately wanted to sink into the ground. "I'm sorry."

"It's okay. You don't have to know right now." Akrash put his arms around her. "Is this okay?" he checked.

She nodded, and buried her head in his shoulder. Her brother's shoulder. Her mind seized on that. She never had siblings. Or maybe she did, she didn't know. Obviously she had a mother. Someone bore her. Someone fed her and changed her.

But Hordak had mothers back to work six weeks after childbirth (at least among the slaves. Soldiers, as far as she knew, didn't have children) and after that they were raised in the creche until they were old enough to work.

She didn't remember a mother other than Casta.

But, Akrash said he didn't either. He was raised by servants. And then, when his parents deemed him old enough, he came to Court with them.

His story was worse than hers. What they *did* to him…

She never asked the details, but Casta said that they had widened the channels that carried his magic.

To understand how terrible it was, she only needed to look at his white fur. The blue eyes with the green pigment burned away. The changed contour of his face. He had rejected them utterly, excising them from his body as if they were a tumor.

Akrash understood what it was to be made powerless, to know no safety except in your own mind.

"Don't tell Mom," she whispered.

The grief on Casta's face, the knowledge that safety was an illusion. The disappointment. The sheer inability to explain what happened made Ariel's stomach roil. That she'd been so careless.

"It was… It was just a bad date."

"All right. If that's what you want." The shoulder under her cheek tensed and he backed up to look at her, putting his hand on her cheek. His blue eyes searched hers. "But, if it was a bad date, I reserve my right to call him out. Make him apologize."

"I don't want to see him. Ever again."

"Okay. I'll ask him to leave Mystacor." He must have seen

something in her eyes. “Ariel, I swear to you, I will not hurt him if I can help it.”

Akrash never lied to her. Well, not about anything important. If she never had to see Khedir, didn’t need to fear running into him in her seminars or on the grounds… “Thank you.”

“Do you think you might be able to sleep?”

“Will you… stay with me?” If he was there she could trust him to keep her safe.

“Of course.”

Ariel had dropped the name Khedir. That same name featured prominently in her mumbling as she had tossed around in nightmare. The arrogant little toad seemed capable of it, but it wasn’t enough. For what he planned, he had to be one hundred percent sure.

He picked up her dirty clothes and examined them. He assumed Ariel wouldn’t want these clothes back. No matter, If she did want them, he would buy her new ones.

Stains were visible. On the front of the dress was a smear of blood that wasn't Ariel’s, testosterone soaked sweat in the fibers. The same scent that was in her hair. On the hem, semen.

Using a tailor’s spell, he isolated those fluids. Normally it was used to preserve a loved one's scent when they were gone. Occasionally, it was used forensically by the watch and Lenio had taught it to him. It would preserve the DNA in the fibers.

And Akrash would recognize the bastard's scent until he died.

The evidence, he preserved in a conjured box. Should his actions this morning become problematic, he would turn this over to

Castaspella.

Mid-morning Jerick knocked on the door. “Miss Ariel? Have you seen Master Akrash?”

“In here,” Akrash called softly.

The door opened. “I beg your pardon, but your bed wasn’t slept in.” His eyes took in the scene: Akrash on the couch, Ariel curled in the bed. The tablet and first aid kit on the side table. Trashcan beside the bed in case Ariel was sick again.

"Ah. I see." His voice was carefully neutral. "Shall I have someone bring breakfast here?"

"Yes, please," Akrash said quietly. "And... maybe just tea and toast for now? Ariel… Had a little too much last night."

Jerick’s nod was slow, understanding; the understanding of a man who’d been head of student housing for a decade before becoming Seneschal. He’d seen “too much” in all its forms.

"Of course, Master Akrash. I'll let Her Grace know you both are here when she wakes."

“Thank you.” Akrash hesitated. He still felt out of his depth, and Jerick was someone he trusted implicitly. It wouldn’t be a betrayal of confidence to say a little more. “I should tell you, It wasn’t alcohol or moonflower.”

Jerick’s eyes met his, sharp with experience. “Indeed?” A pause. “Do you know the substance Miss Ariel imbibed too much of?”

“Glitter.”

The man’s expression darkened. “I see.”

The two words carried the weight of a death knell and his tone held nothing but steel.

“Is there anything else I should know?”

“She told me she had a bad date.”

“A bad date.” The words landed with quiet precision. Jerick’s jaw tightened slightly.

“Yes. That’s what she called it. With Khedir.”

“Khedir?” Jerick’s mouth twisted in an unwonted curl of contempt.

“I was going to go have a word with him.”

Akrash braced for an argument, but Jerick only gave a small nod. “Very good sir.”

Has she spoken with a healer?”

“No. She said she didn’t want to.”

“You know how she is about things like that.”

“I do.” A faint, knowing smile. “You’ve done well. And… if Miss Ariel should need anything of a *delicate* nature, Midwife Muriel is dependable. And discreet.”

Akrash looked down at the conjured box in his hands.

“Jerick. Would you take care of this for me? They’re… mementos. Of said ‘bad date.’”

Something in Jerick’s posture shifted, eyes narrowed in quiet rage. “Of course.” He accepted the box without flinching. “I take it you’ve preserved what matters?”

“Yes. Everything I could. She may… want to do something with it later.”

"Very good, sir." Jerick's voice was smooth as silk and hard as glass. "It'll be kept safe. And ready. Should she decide."

Before he went to speak to Khedir, Akrash stopped to change his robes, donning the pastel shimmersilk that Ariel had given him.

The day after his transformation, before he'd even really had a chance to look at himself, she'd come into his room and shoved the box into his hands with a grin. "Happy birthday, Akrash."

When he'd tried to protest that it wasn't his birthday, she said, "Yes. It is."

Then she'd stepped back and said, "I don't know when that other person's birthday was, but *your* birthday is today."

He'd shed a few tears when he opened it, but tactfully, she pretended not to notice.

That was when she'd made the comment about larval phases.

She'd also said she thought the colors went well with his blue eyes. And so, *Akrash's* story began in pastel silk, a gift from his sister on the first day of his life.

He knew how people like Khedir worked. That was one thing he understood from being the last scion of House Treachery. They valued appearance. If he was going to do the thing, he would go all out.

Though he didn't own much jewelry, he had a few rings. He put all of them on. A lace cravat Casta gave him at the solstice. The badge for his Alchemical Mastery. He didn't need to use a staff for his magic, but he had one he carried because he didn't like to

explain why he never needed a focus. He took a lace handkerchief and tucked it in his breast pocket.

When he was done, he looked like the biggest court fop in Halfmoon.

Perfect.

From what he'd seen of Khedir, he was all about the duels he'd fought, his influence at his father's court and his self proclaimed skill.

Akrash thought he and Kellam would get along famously.

Khedir didn't have a particular mentor, so he lived in general housing, with the journeymen and older apprentices.

Halfway there, a voice called out, "I beg your pardon? Akrash?"

When he turned around, a dark skinned older woman hurried toward him. He thought she was one of the teachers of the young students. "Yes?"

She fell into step beside him and spoke in a low voice, "How is Ariel this morning?"

"She's… well. Why do you ask?"

The woman bit her lip and then seemed to come to a decision. "She seemed to be in some distress last night. I saw her with Khedir. He was trying to take her back to his room, but her shoes were in her hand, as though she had just made an escape. I was going to tell Her Grace when she woke."

That was a complication Akrash had not considered, and he ushered the woman toward the open terrace where they could talk. "It was Khedir?"

"Yes. She seemed relieved to escape him. I walked her home."

“Thank you.” He meant it sincerely. “She’s home. Jerick’s looking after her.” He paused, wondering how much to say. “I was going to have a friendly talk with Khedir.”

THe woman pursed her lips. “Oh?”

“He should really leave before our mother wakes up.”

The woman nodded sharply. “I see.” She glanced around, as though to make sure there really wasn’t anyone near. “I… probably shouldn’t repeat this, but it’s not a secret or anything.” Again that glance around. “It is my understanding that Khedir was asked to leave his placement last year under… mysterious circumstances.”

Good to know.

“Thank you. I fear he may have to do so again. I'm going to explain the depth of his mistake.”

The woman nodded. “I’ll leave it with you, Master Akrash.”

It didn’t take long to find Khedir. Akrash used the traces on Ariel’s dress to cast a simple location spell, and the man was exactly where he’d assumed: lounging alone in the common room of the journeymen’s quarters, looking pleased with himself.

“Did you need something?” Khedir asked, one eyebrow raised as if genuinely puzzled by the intrusion.

Akrash offered a thin, polite smile. “I wonder if I might have a word. About Ariel.”

“Ariel?” He said blankly as though he had no idea what Akrash

was talking about.

"Red haired girl? About so high?" Akrash indicated her height against his neck. "I just needed a quick word. There might have been a misunderstanding. I was hoping to head off any unpleasantness for both you and her."

The man's smile spread slowly, a confiding gesture. "Oh, *her*? Yes, we had a… liaison last night. But I fear she was hurt when I explained there was no future in it."

"Yes, she did seem a little upset," Akrash agreed, his tone one of mild commiseration. "And I do take your point. The social divide between you would obviously create… difficulties."

Khedir relaxed, the tension leaving his shoulders. Prey that did not understand the meaning of 'ambush predator.'

"So, I thought it was better if I came and spoke with you. I fear she is somewhat indisposed this morning."

"Oh, poor dear." Khedir said in a tone of patently false sympathy. "I did warn her about overindulging."

"Well, she doesn't have much experience with alcohol." Akrash shrugged dismissively. "She almost never imbibes, so…" he let the words trail off.

"Yes, I suppose one must give allowances for inexperience. Although, she seemed *quite* experienced in other aspects."

Khedir smirked and Akrash gritted his teeth, hiding it behind his practiced smile.

"I'm so pleased you see the issue." Khedir's smile turned conspiratorial. He leaned in slightly. "Between us, she's a lovely bit of fun, but one must be realistic. I mean, her *background*…" He gave a delicate, dismissive shake of his head. "I was worried she

might… embellish things. You know how they are. It's such a relief you're being sensible about it."

With a wide, friendly smile, he waved at the chair opposite him. Akrash took the invitation. It was hard to make out Khedir's scent notes, because the man had doused himself with cologne.

"Actually, I'm pleased we had this opportunity to speak." Khedir leaned back, resting his arm on the window ledge. "I had heard you were of good family in your own lands?"

"Oh yes, My parents had extensive estates. A very old family."

For a moment Akrash's easy lies faltered. He didn't want to claim them. They were Gideon's. Akrash would *never* claim them.

Even for this.

"But I was raised by my grandfather. He was the chief court physician and royal sorcerer." The grief in his voice was unfeigned. "I was his apprentice."

"What happened?" Khedir asked, voice soft with the false empathy of the nobility.

"One night there was an attempted coup. I was snatched as a hostage. They brought me to the surface. I fear my grandfather is dead and I shall never return to my homeland."

"I'm sorry. That's a damn shame." The man had the good grace to look solemn in respect, but his eyes glittered with calculation. In most kingdoms, the Royal Physician was second in rank only to the royals and could, in matters of health, overrule even the monarch.

"I was fortunate that Her Grace found me and took me in. First as her apprentice and then as… " he let the emotion thicken his throat. "As her son. She adopted me."

“So youre Mystacor's heir?” Again that glint of avarice.

“Oh, no.” Akrash barked a laugh as though Khedir had said something droll. “That would be Ariel.”

The silence stretched for three heartbeats.

"I-I beg your pardon?" Khedir froze, with the expression of someone who had just been clubbed.

"Ariel." Akrash's voice lost its performative warmth. What remained was a scalpel. "Her Grace’s adopted daughter. Ariel is the heir."

“Wait,” Khedir protested. His voice losing its cultured polish, turning coarse with incredulity. “You cannot be serious. That… that *little slut* is the *heir*?”

“Yes. She is Castaspella’s adopted daughter as well as her apprentice.” Akrash laughed again, coldly, “Of course, that also puts Ariel in Bright Moon’s succession.”

“*What?*”

“Oh, my.” Akrash allowed himself a condescending little chuckle. “Didn’t you do your research before you transferred here? Surely you *are* aware that Bright Moon’s monarch must be a queen? Her Grace is Queen Angella’s sister-in-law. First-in-line to be regent until Princess Glimmer is of age. Second-in-line for the throne itself. Which makes Ariel third. Queen Angella confirmed this at the time of Ariel’s adoption.”

Akrash watched Khedir’s face lose color.

“So, as you say, clearly a relationship between the two of you is out of the question. You’re… what? The sixth son? The seventh?” He leaned back casually. “With an older brother who has already bred the traditional ‘heir and a spare’? ” Akrash had taken the time to look up Khedir’s family while he watched Ariel. “And word

has it you’re considered something of a disappointment.”

“Wh-whatever she told you,” Khedir sputtered. “She came back to my room voluntarily!”

“Hmm. Yes. So I understand. *After* being dosed with Glitter.” He tilted his head. “Poison was much used in the old days among my people. Interesting that your kingdom is so backward.”

“I refuse to believe this *fairy-tale*!” Khedir let out a short, ugly laugh. “You expect me to believe the future of Mystacor rests on a former Horde *slave*?”

Akrash leaned forward. "It really doesn’t matter what you believe. And I can prove you were the one who assaulted her." He tapped his alchemy mastery badge. "It was quite simple to isolate both the traces of the drug and the..." A shiver of disgust passed through him. "Fluids you left on her."

"She knew what she was doing!" Khedir's voice rose as he recognized the trap. "Maybe it got rougher than she liked, but she didn't say no."

"The Glitter was blown into her face. Impossible to titrate safely." Akrash's tone remained clinical. "Given Ariel's magical levels, no qualified healer would use this drug on her. Unless..." He paused. "This was an attempted assassination of someone in Bright Moon's succession?"

Khedir's face went from ashen to crimson. "This is nonsense! She’s merely a spiteful little cunt who makes up stories because I hurt her feelings! And clearly, you’re no better!”

"You are fortunate my sister is as politic as she is. She sent me rather than informing Her Grace." Akrash adjusted one of his rings. "She would prefer this incident not cause a war. You might tell your father that when you get home."

"*Home?*" Khedir stood abruptly, the bench scraping back. "You think you can just… What? *Dismiss* me? Like some *servant?*"

"There's a skiff leaving for Shining City in two hours." Akrash brushed nonexistent dust from his lapel. In his periphery, he tracked Khedir’s hand hovering on his weapon, while giving every indication his attention was absorbed by the quality of the stitchwork on his own sleeve. "Be on it. From there you can contact your father for passage home, I’m sure

"No." Khedir's hand dropped to his dueling blade. "I don't think so. You're just some *pet* the Duchess took pity on. You have no authority here."

Akrash stood smoothly, his pastel robes catching the light. "If you're still here when my mother wakes…"

"Your *mother*?" Khedir spat the word. "You’re delusional. She's not your mother, you pathetic stray. And that slave bitch upstairs isn't your sister."

The air went very still.

"I've had enough of this," Khedir snarled, his temper flaring. In one fluid motion, he drew his sword and lunged.

The swordmaster who trained Khedir must have been a fraud. The unnecessary flourish, more suited to the stage, made him slower than rising bread.

Before the sword finished its arc Akrash closed the distance, his right hand flashing out to wrap around the man’s throat and slamming him against the wall. Khedir hadn’t even moved to avoid being trapped in the corner.

The claws on Akrash’s thumb and forefinger rested precisely over each of Khedir’s carotids. With very little pressure he could cut off the circulation. He extended his claws until they just touched the soft flesh under the hinge of his jaw.

Khedir froze, his eyes wide with terror. The cologne could not drown out the stink of his sudden fear sweat. Nor the slight whiff of urine.

“Please understand, I am here unofficially. At Ariel’s request.” Leaning forward, Akrash’s voice dropped to a confidential murmur. “My sister is willing to offer you mercy.”

“Our mother… the Duchess… does not yet know about this. When she does… “ Akrash smiled, showing off his fangs. “Well, there is a reason they call her The Mad Duchess of Mystacor.”

The man sucked in a noisy breath and Akrash could feel him tremble.

“Leave. This morning.” He tilted his head slightly. "Because if you are still here when she wakes, I cannot help you. I cannot protect your family. I cannot save your father's kingdom from what she will do."

The throat under his palm flexed as Khedir gulped.

“This is not a threat.” Akrash murmured, bringing his mouth close to Khedir’s ear, divulging the secret of his survival. “I am preventing a massacre. The choice is yours: a discreet departure, or the wrath of a Duchess who has leveled Horde battalions for less. For your own sake, and your people’s… be wise.”

He was telling Khedir the truth. If Casta woke to this, they would be sending Khedir home in a matchbox, treaties be damned.

If he thought it would help, he would bring Ariel Khedir's head in a box. But she had told him it was a bad date, not a cause for war. He understood. Sometimes dignity was in the story one told oneself.

A brother threatening the life of the man who upset his sister? That gave everyone the deniability they needed and Ariel would never have to see Khedir’s face again.

“Do I have your word?”

Khedir nodded. And Akrash relaxed his hold and backed up.

The minute Akrash’s hand left his throat, Khedir threw himself forward, trying to use his weight to overwhelm the other man and bring the sword up between them.

Akrash sidestepped and raked his claws across Khedir’s face. “Do you think I’m a fool?” he growled at the man who fell to the ground with a sharp cry bleeding profusely from four parallel lacerations.

He pulled the lace handkerchief from his breast. He got down on one knee, pressed the linen to the bleeding wounds, then clamped Khedir’s own hand over it. “Hold that,” he instructed, his voice cold.

“If I see you again, I will not restrain myself. I will kill you on sight. And I will not need magic. Do you understand?”

Khedir’s eyes blazed with hate, but he nodded jerkily. “I understand,” he gasped.

Akrash stood and backed up a step. “So pleased we could take care of this like gentlemen.” He took a moment to straighten his robes.

Khedir stayed down, pressing the cloth hard against his cheek.

Akrash turned on his heel, giving his robes extra flourish, clicked his staff against the stone flow and swept out of the room.

Waking was a fight. Every time she dragged herself from the bottom of the deep pit, an all-consuming lassitude pulled her back under. It was like fevers she'd had as a child, hiding in the bunkroom, sweating it out. Shallow dreams and groggy awakenings blurred together until they became one unbroken stream.

Voices. Akrash and Jerick, talking quietly in the hallway.

"Thank you for speaking with Muriel."

"Oh, you are most welcome. Was she helpful?"

"Yes. I told her it was for a young woman I'd had over. I wasn't sure Ariel would be comfortable with anyone else knowing."

"And the young man?"

"Khedir? We had a conversation. He's packing his bags."

A pause.

"Very good, sir."

"Akrash?" Ariel called weakly, cracking her eyes open with great difficulty. She cleared her throat and tried again. "Akrash?"

He came in wearing the robes she had bought him. The ones that went so well with his eyes.

"How are you feeling?" His hands were warm around hers.

"I hurt," she whispered.

"I know." He let go of her hand to reach into his pocket. "I wasn't sure if you needed this, but I got this from one of the midwives."

Ariel recognized it. A potion to prevent conception. Tears flooded down her face, hot on her icy skin.

"Ariel, I'm sorry if I overstepped. I told her it was for a friend of mine, I never brought up your name, I swear."

She leaned forward and buried her face in his shoulder.

"Thank you," she sobbed. "You said… You said he was leaving?"

"Yeah. Packing his bags even as we speak. He'll be on a skiff out of here this afternoon."

Relief flooded through her. She would never have to see him. Never have to worry about running into him in the halls, at meals, in the classroom. She'd never have to hear people gossiping and wonder if they were laughing at her.

"What happened?"

Akrash sat back smirking. "He drew on me." He said it casually, like it was nothing.

"Did he hurt you?" Ariel's eyes raked over him. Khedir always went around with his dueling sword, talking about his successes.

"Oh, he tried. Very dramatic. Very scary." Akrash lifted his hand and extended his claws. "Very stupid." He grinned. "He was so scared he pissed himself."

The laugh that burst from her was half sob. "He *what*?"

"Pissed. Himself. I could smell it."

Something in her chest loosened and she giggled. The laughter seemed to have a life of its own, she found she couldn't talk. She met his eyes and he began to giggle too.

For about fifteen minutes, neither of them could stop. Every time one of them got a handle on the laughter, they'd look at each other and that just set them off again.

"Th-thank you," she gasped. The laughter finally dissolved into

deep, wracking cries that felt like they came from the pit of her stomach.

He leaned forward to put his arms around her again and she hugged him hard, sobbing uncontrollably now.

“Shh. Remember? That’s what family does.”

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!